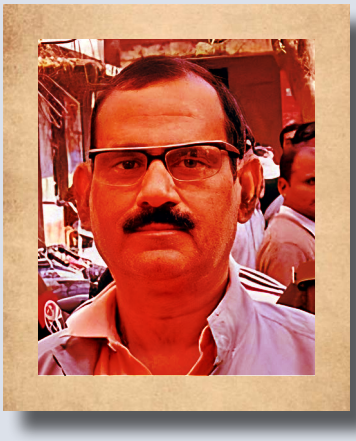
THE BIG DONS OF POORVANCHAL



VIJAY MISHRA

Area of operation
Bhadohi

No. of cases: **83**

A four-time MLA from Bhadohi district's Gyanpur town, Mishra has the second-highest number of cases among the 66 big dons the UP government is keeping an eye on. Mishra started with a petrol pump and a transport business, and then expanded into sand mining and land deals. He was said to be close to then Samajwadi Party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav, who is said to have helped Mishra escape in a chopper when the police came to arrest him in 2009. In 2010, Mishra made headlines over the bomb attack on Nand Gopal Gupta, a minister of state in the BSP government then and currently a minister in the Yogi cabinet. Mishra contested the 2012 assembly election from jail and won. In 2017, he was expelled from SP for "anti-party activities". He was booked under the Goonda Act on July 18, 2020, for threatening a contractor who had bagged the rights for charging toll at the Aurai toll plaza on National Highway-2. On August 14, 2020, Mishra was arrested after a relative, Krishna Kant Tiwari, had an FIR lodged against him over a property dispute. The Bhadohi police cancelled two of his arms licences last year, and properties worth crores belonging to him, his family and gang members have been attached earlier. In a 2020 video, Mishra said he was being targeted by the Yogi government because he was a 'Brahmin'.



MUKHTAR ANSARI

Areas of operation:
Ghazipur, Mau, Varanasi

No. of cases: **61**

The 59-year-old Ansari, a five-time MLA from Mau, has been in jail for more than 15 years now. However, he was convicted for the first time only last year, in two cases.

With an imposing six-feet-tall frame, and immaculately dressed in white kurta-pyjama, scarf and sunglasses, Ansari evokes fear and awe in equal measure in and around Ghazipur, Mau and Varanasi.

Ansari's father, Haji Subhanullah Ansari, was a Communist leader, while his paternal grandfather, Mukhtar Ahmed Ansari, was a Congressman. Ansari himself

tion, and one whose upper echelons ramified right into the corridors of power, across party lines. Yogi got the state administration and police to draw up a list of 66 top mafia lords across the state, including Atiq Ahmed (see *UP's Most Wanted)*, and an extended network of 1,105 minor dons who lord it over their niches—30 in illegal mining, 228 in illicit liquor, 168 in cattle trade, 347 in shady land transactions, 18 with their talons in education rackets, and 359 miscellaneous ones. Exhaustive dossiers were then prepared on the dramatis personae, detailing all infractions, so as to zero in on each crime lord's vulnerabilities.

Going after such a systemic monster was less about high-octane action involving edgy and glamorous encounter specialists and more akin to the gruelling grind of police procedurals. First, the patterns were studied. What was it exactly that was enabling such impunity? Why could crime lords never be brought to book? Where were the chinks in the system? How could the legal machinery be used to go to war on its own entrenched inertia? The findings were not surprising. Many of the dons had more than a hundred criminal cases registered against them over several decades but had never been prosecuted. Says Ashutosh Pandey, additional director-general of police in UP, "Earlier, mafia lords got acquitted because of weakness